

# Research Protocol

*Intergenerational Goal Continuity and Social Evolution Theory*

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| Document ID                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | ASU-IGC-001-PROTOCOL                                  |
| Owner                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             | Toby William Duffield                                 |
| Version                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           | 1.0                                                   |
| Issue date                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        | 18 September 2026                                     |
| Classification                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | Public method / controlled master                     |
| Review status                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | External review pending                               |
| Related publication                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | <a href="https://asultd.com/">https://asultd.com/</a> |
| <b>Status boundary:</b> This protocol defines how the theory should be investigated. It is not evidence that the theory is correct, does not report a completed systematic review and is not a claim of peer review or institutional endorsement. |                                                       |

# Document control

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## Purpose

To convert a developing theoretical framework into an auditable research programme with stable terminology, numbered propositions, explicit alternatives, evidence thresholds, disconfirmation criteria, ethical boundaries and revision controls.

## Scope

- Family and social transmission of priorities, narratives, practices and expectations.
- Moderating social, institutional, economic, historical and informational conditions.
- Disruption, rejection and redirection of continuity.
- The near-term cultural and behavioural effects of AI-rich environments.
- A separately labelled speculative annex for possible long-term biological questions.

## Status taxonomy

| Status                      | Meaning                                                                       |
|-----------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Established evidence domain | A wider field with identifiable evidence; not proof of the ASU model.         |
| Supported interpretation    | A reasoned reading consistent with evidence but open to alternatives.         |
| Working hypothesis          | A proposition intended for testing and possible rejection.                    |
| Speculative hypothesis      | A low-confidence, long-range possibility not established by current evidence. |
| Open research question      | A defined issue without a predetermined conclusion.                           |

## Core terminology

| Term            | Working definition                                                                                    |
|-----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Goal continuity | Recurring direction or priority across time; not a single conscious family objective.                 |
| Transmission    | Learning, modelling, expectation, narrative, resource, network or institutional pathways.             |
| Pressure        | A persistent condition that changes incentives, attention, exposure, constraint or perceived risk.    |
| Adaptation      | A behavioural, cognitive, cultural or institutional response; not automatically biological evolution. |
| Interruption    | A material weakening, redirection or ending of an earlier pattern.                                    |

# Numbered propositions

| ID  | Proposition                                                                                                                  | Disconfirming or weakening evidence                                                       |
|-----|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| P01 | Recurring family narratives, expectations and practices may influence later priorities through learning and socialisation.   | No association after credible controls, or better explanation by unrelated factors.       |
| P02 | Social, institutional, economic and historical conditions may moderate whether continuity strengthens, changes or ends.      | No meaningful moderation across well-designed comparative studies.                        |
| P03 | Separation, rejection, mobility, new relationships and institutional change may redirect or interrupt continuity.            | Predicted disruptions do not alter measured outcomes.                                     |
| P04 | AI-rich environments may change which cognitive skills are practised, delegated, rewarded or neglected.                      | Longitudinal evidence shows no relevant change or effects are better explained elsewhere. |
| P05 | Many interacting personal and group trajectories may contribute to changes in institutions, norms and collective priorities. | Individual-level mechanisms do not scale or aggregate as predicted.                       |

## Research questions

1. Which mechanisms transmit priorities or narratives across generations?
2. Under which conditions does continuity strengthen, fragment, change or end?
3. How much observed continuity remains after socioeconomic, institutional and genetic confounding are addressed?
4. Which AI-related changes persist beyond novelty, education and workplace design effects?
5. Can individual-level mechanisms be linked credibly to group or institutional outcomes?

## Competing explanations

- General social learning and cultural evolution
- Developmental psychology and family systems
- Socioeconomic persistence and institutional effects
- Behavioural genetics and gene–environment correlation
- Selection, reporting, memory and survivorship bias
- Chance, individual agency and within-family variation

# Evidence and review method

## Evidence thresholds

| Control           | Minimum expectation                                                                                                         |
|-------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Claim fit         | The source must address the narrow claim, population and mechanism attributed to it.                                        |
| Source quality    | Prefer systematic reviews, peer-reviewed primary research, official statistics and primary law or policy where appropriate. |
| Causal restraint  | Association must not be restated as causation, heredity, intention or biological evolution.                                 |
| Contrary evidence | Null, negative and credible alternative findings must be logged and assessed.                                               |
| Triangulation     | Stronger conclusions require convergence across methods, populations or data sources.                                       |
| Revision          | Propositions must be narrowed, changed or retired when evidence requires it.                                                |

## Structured literature review

1. Fix the proposition, population, mechanism or exposure, comparator and outcome.
2. Record databases, search strings, dates, filters and supplementary searches.
3. Apply written inclusion and exclusion criteria and retain exclusion reasons.
4. Extract design, sample, measures, findings, uncertainty, limitations, funding and relevance.
5. Assess quality and exact claim fit without converting association into causation.
6. Synthesis must report convergence, inconsistency, uncertainty, gaps and alternatives.

## Minimum evidence record

Source ID; proposition ID; citation; stable link or DOI; source type; research question; jurisdiction; population; design; sample; measures; main result; effect or uncertainty where reported; limitations; conflicts or funding; support/challenge/neutral classification; reviewer note; review date.

## Evidence-to-claim decision

| Decision     | Rule                                                                                                              |
|--------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Support      | The finding is materially consistent with the defined proposition and credible alternatives have been considered. |
| Challenge    | The finding is inconsistent with the proposition or supports a materially better explanation.                     |
| Neutral      | The source is relevant context but does not discriminate between the proposition and alternatives.                |
| Insufficient | Method, sample, reporting or claim fit does not support a                                                         |

| Decision | Rule                            |
|----------|---------------------------------|
|          | reliable directional judgement. |

# Ethics, governance and revision

## Human research boundary

Research involving people or sensitive records requires an appropriate lawful basis, informed consent where applicable, data minimisation, privacy protection, safeguarding, secure retention and independent ethical review when required. This document does not itself authorise participant research.

## AI extension

The near-term programme concerns cultural and behavioural change: skill practice, delegation, verification, judgement, dependence and institutional power. Long-term biological change is a speculative question requiring a much higher evidential threshold and is not inferred from short-term observations.

## External review

Seek conceptual, methods, ethics, data-protection, legal and lived-experience review appropriate to the output. Informal contact, silence or private feedback must not be represented as endorsement. Publish review scope, date, permitted attribution, response and resulting revision where permission allows.

## Revision control

| Version | Date              | Change                               | Approval     |
|---------|-------------------|--------------------------------------|--------------|
| 1.0     | 18 September 2026 | Initial controlled research protocol | Owner issued |

## Review record

| Reviewer / organisation | Scope | Date | Outcome / actions |
|-------------------------|-------|------|-------------------|
|                         |       |      |                   |
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|                         |       |      |                   |

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